rising from the open ovens and the old imperial mosque looming in the background, one could be back in medieval Delhi. Bernier, however, was quite suspicious of the kebab shops for he wrote, ‘There is no trusting their dishes, composed for aught I know, of the flesh of camels, horses or perhaps oxen who have died of disease’. Perhaps he had suffered a bad case of Delhi Belly during his stay.

MONSIEUR TAVERNIER, I PRESUME

At the time that Bernier was travelling through the Mughal Empire, there were many other Europeans—merchants, officials, mercenaries, adventurers—who were also in the country and have left us colourful accounts of their experiences. One of these was Jean-Baptiste Tavernier, also a Frenchman. In the winter of 1665–66, he travelled from Agra to Bengal and wrote about the experiences. We know from his writings that the imperial highways were full of bullock-cart caravans carrying rice, salt, corn, and so on. Although most caravans consisted of one or two hundred carts, some were huge, with 10,000 to 12,000 oxen. When two large caravans going in opposite directions encountered each other on a narrow section of the road, it could take two to three days to pass each other. One can imagine the dust, the noise and the tempers.

The bullock-cart caravans were driven by nomadic castes called Manaris who travelled the trade routes with their families and belongings. At every stop a temporary village of tents would be set up. Each group had a chieftain who could be identified by a string of pearls. Often there would be quarrels between the leaders of rival caravans and matters could be escalated all the way up to the Emperor[17]. In other words, the ill-tempered truck drivers that one encounters in modern Indian highways have a long lineage.

Tavernier tells us that travellers had a choice between two kinds of transport—light carriages pulled by bullocks and palanquins carried by men. The former cost about a rupee a day and came with luxuries like cushions and curtains. The palanquins needed about six people to lift and a